

ProfileSA — Product Requirements Document (PRD)

The Full Blueprint: Phase 1 Through Monopoly

Vision: Own the verified professional trust graph of the world — starting with South Africa. Replace the self-reported CV with proof. Replace isolated platform reputation systems with portable trust infrastructure. Become the identity layer the internet was supposed to have.

Codename: The Real Graph — a deliberate, phased capture of every node in the professional trust and hiring network.

Table of Contents

1. [Product Overview](#)
 2. [User Personas](#)
 3. [Phase 1 — ProfileSA \(Verified Professional Profile\)](#)
 4. [Phase 2 — Profile Recruit \(Hiring Graph\)](#)
 5. [Phase 3 — Profile API \(Trust Infrastructure\)](#)
 6. [Phase 4 — Profile Verify \(Fake CV Detection\)](#)
 7. [Phase 5 — Profile Identity \(Universal Trust Score\)](#)
 8. [Platform Architecture](#)
 9. [The Graph Data Strategy](#)
 10. [Monetisation Roadmap](#)
 11. [Non-Functional Requirements](#)
 12. [Risk Register](#)
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1. Product Overview

Problem Statement

The professional world runs on reputation — but reputation is currently:

- **Self-reported** (LinkedIn, CVs) — anyone can claim anything
- **Isolated** (Upwork rating, Airbnb score, GitHub stars) — no single truth
- **Ephemeral** (reference calls) — verbal, unrecorded, not portable
- **Gated** (background checks) — expensive, slow, only used at hiring stage

The result: employers make million-rand hiring decisions on unverifiable information. Talented people without the right network or credentials are systematically shut out of opportunities.

Fraud is endemic. And the actual graph of who worked with whom, who vouches for whom, and who genuinely has proven skills — exists but has never been mapped.

Solution

Proofile is the verified professional trust graph. A living, publicly accessible record of what you've actually done, verified by the real people you did it with — replacing the CV as the primary professional identity document, and eventually replacing every platform's isolated reputation system with a single, portable trust score.

The Journey Map We Own



Core Principles

- **Proof over claims** — every signal on Proofile must be verifiable by a real person or a public data source
- **Portable reputation** — your trust score belongs to you, not to any single platform
- **The reviewer is as important as the review** — a review from a verified, high-score reviewer carries more weight. This is PageRank for people.
- **Infrastructure not product** — the consumer profile is the engine. The graph is the asset. The API is the business.
- **Democratise access** — a self-taught developer from Khayelitsha with 5 verified reviews should beat a titled graduate with none

2. User Personas

Persona A — The Skilled Professional Locked Out (Primary)

- **Name:** Kagiso, 26, Johannesburg
- **Background:** Self-taught developer. Bootcamp graduate (WeThinkCode). 2 years freelance work. 800 GitHub contributions. No degree. No LinkedIn network of senior people.
- **Pain:** Gets filtered out before interviews because HR systems sort by degree. His real skills and work record are invisible. References are a phone call nobody makes.
- **Proofile value:** His verified reviews from 3 clients and 1 senior developer mentor + his GitHub signal = a credibility profile that bypasses the degree filter.

Persona B — The Mis-hired Employer (B2B Primary)

- **Name:** Nomsa, 38, Cape Town
- **Role:** Head of Engineering at a 60-person SA tech company
- **Pain:** Hired someone with a stellar CV and LinkedIn profile. Four months in — they couldn't do the job. Reference check was a rubber stamp from a friend. Cost: 4 months salary + recruitment fee + team disruption.
- **Profile value:** Profile Recruit shows her candidates with verified reviews from real managers. She can see the actual graph — who this person really worked with, what those people actually said.

Persona C — The Proud Manager (Viral Growth Engine)

- **Name:** Sipho, 42, Durban
- **Role:** CTO who has mentored and promoted dozens of developers over 15 years
- **Behaviour:** Takes genuine pride in the careers he's shaped. Informally vouches for former team members all the time — phone calls, WhatsApp messages, LinkedIn endorsements.
- **Profile value:** ProfileSA gives him a public, permanent, credible place to put those vouches. When he vouches for someone on Profile, his credibility transfers visibly. He becomes a node. His vouches become the most trusted signal on the platform.

Persona D — The Marketplace / Platform (API Customer)

- **Company:** SA fintech offering freelancer payment services
- **Pain:** High fraud rate at onboarding. KYC is expensive. New users have no track record on their platform.
- **Profile value:** Call the Profile API at signup. Get a trust score. Instantly know if this user has a verified professional history — not just a phone number and ID.

Persona E — The HR Manager Burned by Fake CVs

- **Name:** Lerato, 35, Johannesburg
 - **Role:** HR Manager, 200-person financial services firm
 - **Pain:** Manually checks qualifications and calls references for every hire. It takes weeks. Still gets fooled by sophisticated CV fraud.
 - **Profile value:** Profile Verify (Phase 4) — paste a candidate's profile link, get instant verification of their claimed work history against the graph.
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3. Phase 1 — ProfileSA

Timeline: Months 1-6 **Goal:** Prove that SA professionals will actively solicit verified reviews from real managers, colleagues, and clients — and that those reviewers will complete them

3.1 Profile Creation

Requirement	Detail
Sign up	Email or Google OAuth
Profile fields	Full name, headline (e.g. "Backend Developer"), city, industry, profile photo, bio (300 chars)
Public URL	prooflesa.com/[username] — chosen at signup
Work history	Company name, role, start date, end date / current, brief description (200 chars)
Multiple entries	Unlimited work history entries
Edit anytime	Users can update all fields — changes are versioned, not deleted
Profile completeness	Visual indicator — "Your profile is 60% complete" prompts action

3.2 Verified Review System

Review Request Flow

Step	Detail
1. Select entry	User selects a work history entry to request a review for
2. Enter reviewer	Name + email of reviewer. Required: their relationship (managed me / colleague / client / mentored me)
3. Send	System sends branded email with personal context
4. Reviewer opens	No account required. One-click form.
5. Review form	Relationship confirmation, star rating (1-5), written review (50-500 chars), skills endorsement (multi-select)
6. Reviewer name	Full name and title displayed on review — no anonymity. This is a feature, not a bug.
7. Published	Review appears on profile within seconds of submission
8. Notification	Profile owner notified immediately

Review Display

Element	Detail
Reviewer identity	Full name, job title, company — all public
Verification badge	✓ Verified (reviewer confirmed relationship)
Weight indicator	Reviews from high-Profile-Score reviewers shown with subtle visual weight
Grouped by role	Reviews grouped under the work history entry they relate to
Overall rating	Aggregate star rating across all reviews — shown prominently

Review Integrity Rules

- Reviewer cannot be the profile owner (blocked by email match)
- Same reviewer cannot review the same person twice for the same role
- Reviewer email domain checked against company domain where possible (flags mismatches)
- Reviews can be disputed — flagged for manual review by Profile team
- Reviewer can update or retract a review — retraction is noted publicly ("This review was retracted by the reviewer")

3.3 Proofile Score (The PageRank for People)

Version 1 (MVP) — Transparent Formula:

Proofile Score =
 (Average star rating × 30%)
 + (Number of verified reviews, capped at 20, normalised × 25%)
 + (Reviewer seniority score average × 25%)
 + (Profile completeness × 10%)
 + (Cross-platform signal bonus × 10%)

Reviewer Seniority Score:

- C-suite / Founder: 10 points
- Director / VP: 8 points
- Manager / Senior: 6 points
- Peer / Colleague: 4 points
- Client: 7 points
- Junior / Report: 3 points

Seniority determined by reviewer's self-declared title — upgraded when reviewer has their own verified Proofile with high score

Why transparency matters: Users must understand how to improve their score. Hidden algorithms breed distrust. Proofile's score is a coaching tool, not a black box.

3.4 Skills Verification

State	Display	Requirement
Self-reported	"Python" (no badge)	User adds it themselves
Endorsed	"Python ✓ ×3"	3+ reviewers selected it in their review
Highly Verified	"Python ✓ ✓ ×8"	8+ reviewers, at least 2 senior-level
Platform Verified	"Python ⚡ GitHub: 1,200 contributions"	Cross-platform data confirms it

Standard Skill Library:

- Technical: 200 pre-defined skills across engineering, data, design, product
- Business: 100 skills across sales, marketing, finance, operations, HR
- Soft skills: 50 skills (leadership, communication, etc.) — endorsable but always shown separately from technical skills

- Custom: User can add custom skills — shown as "Unverified Custom Skill" until endorsed

3.5 Cross-Platform Signals (MVP)

Platform	Integration Method	Signal
GitHub	Public API (URL-based)	Years active, total contributions, top languages, public repos
LinkedIn	URL link only (Phase 1)	"Profile exists" — full integration Phase 2
Portfolio/Website	URL link	Displayed as external link
Upwork	URL link (Phase 1)	Full integration Phase 2

3.6 Public Profile Features

Feature	Detail
Public URL	proofilesa.com/[username]
Share button	Generates link + pre-written share message
QR code	Generated for every profile — for in-person use
OG image	Auto-generated preview card for WhatsApp, Twitter, LinkedIn sharing
Download	"Download as PDF" option — formats profile as a modern CV (Phase 1.5)
Privacy options	Public (indexed) / Link-only (not indexed) / Private (hidden)

3.7 Phase 1 Success Criteria

Metric	90-Day Target	6-Month Target
Profiles created	2,000	10,000
Review requests sent	5,000	25,000
Review completion rate	40%+	45%+
Verified reviews published	2,000	11,000
Profiles shared externally	30%	40%
Reviewers who then create own profile	20%	30%
D30 retention	30%+	40%+

4. Phase 2 — Proofile Recruit

Timeline: Months 7-14 **Trigger:** 10,000 profiles with 30,000+ verified reviews in the graph **Goal:** Monetise the hiring graph. Sell verified talent intelligence to SA employers and recruiters.

4.1 Recruiter Search

Feature	Detail
Search by	Role, skill (verified only filter), city, industry, Proofile Score range
Sort by	Proofile Score, most verified, most recently active, closest match
Filter: verified only	Toggle to show only profiles with minimum N verified reviews
Graph view	"Show me who this candidate has worked with that I also know" — network overlap
Candidate card	Shows score, top verified skills, 1 review excerpt, reviewer names
Unlock full profile	Recruiter purchases access or uses subscription credits

4.2 Hiring Graph Intelligence

This is the feature LinkedIn cannot replicate. Built from the graph assembled in Phase 1:

Feature	Detail
Network overlap	"You know 3 people who have worked with this candidate directly"
Referral path	"Your colleague Nomsa managed this person at Takealot 2 years ago"
Company talent map	"These 12 verified candidates all came from Bash.com's engineering team"
Poaching alerts	Recruiters can set alerts when candidates from target companies become active
Trust chain	"This candidate was reviewed by someone you have hired before successfully"

4.3 Pricing Model

Tier	Price (per month)	Includes
Starter	R2,500	10 full profile unlocks, basic search

Tier	Price (per month)	Includes
Growth	R7,500	40 unlocks, graph intelligence, email candidates
Scale	R15,000	Unlimited unlocks, ATS integration, API access
Enterprise	Custom	White-label, bulk verification, dedicated support

4.4 ATS Integration (Phase 2.5)

- Integrate with common SA ATS tools (BambooHR, Greenhouse, Workable)
- Recruiters can pull Proofile data directly into candidate profiles
- One-click "Request Proofile Verification" from within the ATS
- Webhook support for real-time updates when a candidate's score changes

4.5 Phase 2 Success Criteria

Metric	Target (6 months post-launch)
Paying recruiter accounts	50
Monthly recurring revenue	R500,000
Candidates contacted via Proofile	1,000/month
Hires made via Proofile (tracked)	50/month
Recruiter churn rate	< 10%/month

5. Phase 3 — Proofile API

Timeline: Months 15-24 **Trigger:** 50,000 verified profiles. Proofile Score is trusted and understood in the market. **Goal:** Become the trust infrastructure layer for any platform that needs to verify human identity and reputation.

5.1 The Trust Score API

Any platform can call the Proofile API with a user's email or Proofile ID and receive:

json

```
{
  "proofile_score": 87,
  "score_confidence": "high",
  "verified_reviews": 8,
  "verified_employment_years": 4.5,
  "top_verified_skills": ["React", "Node.js", "Team Leadership"],
  "cross_platform_signals": {
    "github": { "active": true, "years": 3, "contributions": 1240 },
    "linkedin": { "verified": true }
  },
  "last_review_date": "2025-11-01",
  "profile_url": "https://proofile.com/kagiso"
}
```

5.2 Target API Customers

Sector	Use Case	Willingness to Pay
Fintech / Lending	Creditworthiness signal for thin-file borrowers	Very High
Freelance platforms	Onboarding fraud reduction	High
Property / Rental	Tenant verification	High
Gig economy (delivery, rideshare)	Driver / worker verification	Medium
SaaS platforms	User identity confidence	Medium
Insurance	Risk assessment for business owners	High
B2B marketplaces	Supplier verification	High

5.3 API Pricing

Tier	Price	Volume
Startup	R500/month	500 API calls/month
Growth	R2,000/month	5,000 calls/month
Scale	R8,000/month	50,000 calls/month
Enterprise	Custom	Unlimited + SLA

5.4 Phase 3 Success Criteria

Metric	Target
API customers	30
Monthly API revenue	R300,000
API calls per month	500,000
Partner platform integrations	10

6. Phase 4 — Proofile Verify

Timeline: Months 20–30 **Trigger:** API is proven. B2B relationships established with HR firms.

Goal: Become the standard pre-employment verification tool for SA businesses. Kill the fake CV.

6.1 Instant CV Verification

- HR manager receives a candidate's CV
- They paste candidate details (name + claimed work history) into Proofile Verify
- System cross-references against the graph:
 - Does a verified Proofile exist for this person?
 - Do their claimed roles match verified roles in the graph?
 - Are there red flags — gaps, mismatched companies, reviewer identity inconsistencies?
- Output: Verification report — Confirmed / Partially Confirmed / Flagged / No Data

6.2 Background Check Integration

- Partner with existing SA background check providers (MIE, Managed Integrity Evaluation)
- Proofile adds the social/reputation layer they don't have
- MIE confirms formal records (qualifications, criminal). Proofile confirms professional reality (did they actually do the work, do real people vouch for them).
- Combined offering sold to enterprise HR departments

6.3 Verification Report Pricing

Product	Price
Single verification	R150 per candidate
Bulk (50+ per month)	R100 per candidate
Enterprise subscription	R10,000/month (unlimited)

6.4 Phase 4 Success Criteria

Metric	Target
Verifications per month	5,000
Enterprise subscribers	20
Monthly revenue (Verify product)	R750,000
Fake CV detection rate	Measurable and publishable stat

7. Phase 5 — Proofile Identity

Timeline: Months 30–48 **Trigger:** API trusted across multiple sectors. 200,000+ verified profiles.
Goal: Become the portable professional identity layer for Africa — and then the world.

7.1 Proofile Passport

- A user's complete, verified professional identity — portable across any platform
- One click: "Sign in with Proofile" — like Sign in with Google, but it brings your reputation with it
- Platform receives: verified identity + trust score + relevant professional context
- User controls exactly what each platform sees

7.2 Cross-Border Verification

- SA professionals working in or applying to opportunities in Kenya, Nigeria, Ghana, UK, UAE
- Proofile Passport recognised across borders — one verified record, globally readable
- Partner with international credential verification bodies for formal qualification layer

7.3 Proofle for Institutions

- Universities and bootcamps issue verified graduation credentials directly on Proofle
- Employers issue verified employment records directly (replacing reference letters)
- Government departments issue verified professional licences (engineers, doctors, lawyers)
- Proofle becomes the notarised professional record of African careers

7.4 Phase 5 Success Criteria

Metric	Target
Verified profiles	1,000,000+
Countries active	10+ African markets
"Sign in with Proofle" integrations	100+ platforms
Monthly revenue (all streams)	R10,000,000+

8. Platform Architecture

8.1 Tech Stack

Layer	Technology	Rationale
Frontend (MVP)	React PWA	Fast to ship, no App Store friction
Frontend (Phase 2+)	React Native	Native app when scale justifies
Backend	Node.js + Express	Full JS stack, fast iteration
Database	PostgreSQL (via Supabase)	Relational for graph edges, scalable
Graph database (Phase 2)	Neo4j or PostgreSQL recursive queries	Hiring graph traversal and relationship queries
Auth	Supabase Auth	Email + Google + future SSO
Email	Resend or Postmark	High deliverability for review request emails
GitHub API	Public REST API	Profile signal integration
OG Images	Vercel OG	Profile share cards

Layer	Technology	Rationale
Search (Phase 2)	Algolia or Meilisearch	Fast skill and candidate search
API layer (Phase 3)	REST + GraphQL	Flexible for diverse API customers
Analytics	PostHog (self-hosted)	Full behavioural data ownership
Hosting	Vercel + Railway	Cheap, fast, scalable early
CDN	Cloudflare	Performance + DDoS protection

8.2 Core Data Models

User / Profile

```
id, username, email, full_name, headline, city, industry,
bio, profile_photo_url, proofile_score, profile_visibility,
github_url, linkedin_url, portfolio_url, created_at, updated_at
```

Work History Entry

```
id, user_id, company_name, role_title, start_date, end_date,
is_current, description, created_at
```

Review

```
id, reviewer_email, reviewer_name, reviewer_title, reviewer_company,
reviewee_id, work_entry_id, relationship_type, star_rating,
written_review, endorsed_skills[], status (pending/published/retracted),
reviewer_proofile_id (nullable), created_at
```

Skill

```
id, user_id, skill_name, is_custom, endorsement_count,
verified_by_platforms[], created_at
```

Review Request

```
id, user_id, work_entry_id, reviewer_email, reviewer_name,
status (sent/viewed/completed/expired), sent_at,
reminder_sent_at, completed_at, token (unique link)
```

Graph Edge (Phase 2)

```
id, from_user_id, to_user_id, edge_type (managed/colleague/client/mentored),
company, period_start, period_end, weight, created_at
```

API Key (Phase 3)

```
id, organisation_id, key_hash, plan_tier, calls_this_month,
monthly_limit, created_at, last_used_at
```

8.3 The Graph Architecture

Phase 1 builds a relational database. Phase 2 adds graph traversal.

Every verified review creates a directed, weighted edge in the graph:

```
Reviewer → [relationship_type, weight, period] → Reviewee
```

Graph queries power:

- "Who do I know who knows this candidate?" (2-hop traversal)
- "Who are the most trusted nodes in the SA tech industry?" (PageRank)
- "Which companies produce the highest-score talent?" (node aggregation)
- "What is the trust chain between any two professionals?" (shortest path)

This graph is the moat. It cannot be replicated without the verified review data. It grows in accuracy and value with every new review.

9. The Graph Data Strategy

9.1 What We Collect and Why

Data	Source	Value
Employment history (verified)	Work entries + review confirmation	Actual career graph
Manager/colleague relationships	Review relationship types	Hierarchy and peer graph
Skill endorsements	Reviewer endorsement	True skill distribution in SA workforce
Review sentiment	Written review text	Professional reputation signals
GitHub activity	Public API	Technical skill verification

Data	Source	Value
Proffile Score over time	Calculated	Career trajectory modelling
Recruiter search queries	Platform usage	Market demand signals
Hire outcomes (Phase 2+)	Recruiter feedback	Ground truth for model accuracy

9.2 Privacy and Ethics (Non-Negotiable)

- **POPIA compliant from day one** — no exceptions
- **Reviews are public and attributed** — the reviewer's name is always shown. Accountability is the integrity mechanism.
- **Users control their profile visibility** — public, link-only, or private
- **API data is aggregated and anonymised** — individual profiles are never sold via API without explicit user consent
- **Right to erasure** — users can delete their profile and all associated reviews. Reviewer's review is removed but the reviewer's identity is not retroactively hidden from their own history.
- **Dispute mechanism** — users can dispute any review. Disputed reviews are flagged pending investigation.

9.3 The Compounding Flywheel



Each loop makes the score more accurate, the graph more complete, and the platform more defensible.

10. Monetisation Roadmap

Phase	Product	Model	Target Monthly Revenue
1	Free (build the asset)	—	R0
2	Proffile Recruit	R2,500–R15,000/month SaaS	R500,000
3	Proffile API	R500–R8,000/month + usage	R300,000
4	Proffile Verify	R150/verification + enterprise	R750,000
5	Proffile Passport / Identity	Platform licensing + enterprise	R5,000,000+
All	Proffile Premium (individual)	R79/month	R500,000+

Proffile Premium (individual) features:

- See who viewed your profile
- Analytics: which skills are getting attention, which roles your profile is matching for
- Priority placement in recruiter searches
- Custom profile domain (kagiso.proffile.com)
- PDF export with Proffile branding and QR code
- API access for personal use (share your trust score with any platform)

11. Non-Functional Requirements

Performance

- Profile page load: < 1.5 seconds
- Review submission (end to end): < 2 seconds
- API response time: < 200ms (p95)
- 99.9% uptime SLA (from Phase 3 onward)

Security

- All data encrypted in transit (TLS 1.3) and at rest (AES-256)
- API keys hashed, never stored in plaintext
- Review request tokens are single-use and expire after 30 days
- Rate limiting on all public endpoints
- Penetration testing before Phase 3 API launch

- POPIA compliance audit annually

Scalability

- Database designed for horizontal scaling from Phase 1
- Graph queries optimised before Phase 2 launch
- API infrastructure designed for 10x expected load from launch

Accessibility

- WCAG 2.1 AA compliance
- Screen reader compatible
- High contrast mode
- Low-bandwidth optimised (important for SA network conditions)

12. Risk Register

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Low review completion rate	Medium	Critical	Polish the review email. Make it take < 2 minutes. Test obsessively.
Fake reviews from friends	High	High	Email domain matching. Reviewer identity verification. Community flagging. Score weighting by reviewer credibility.
Employer legal challenges to public reviews	Low	High	Clear terms of service. Review dispute mechanism. Defamation policy with SA legal counsel.
LinkedIn builds this feature	Low	Medium	Network effect and data moat are the defence. LinkedIn is a US company that moves slowly. Speed is your advantage.
POPIA violation	Low	Critical	Legal review before launch. Privacy-by-design architecture. POPIA officer appointed at launch.
Low recruiter adoption (Phase 2)	Medium	High	Seed with 10 founding recruiter partners before public launch. Offer free trials.
Graph data too sparse to be useful	Medium	High	Don't launch Phase 2 recruiting until graph has minimum 30,000 verified edges.

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Domain name (proofile.com) acquisition fails	Low	Low	ProofileSA operates independently. getproofile.com as fallback. Legal review of trademark before acquisition attempt.

Appendix: The Full Conspiracy — One Paragraph

ProofileSA launches as a free profile page — prettier and more credible than LinkedIn for people who actually have something to prove. Users invite their managers to leave verified reviews. Those managers get emails, click through, leave reviews — and then create their own profiles. The graph builds. The data accumulates. By the time Proofile has 50,000 verified profiles and 150,000 verified review edges, it has something no other company on the continent has: the actual, verified map of who worked with whom, who vouches for whom, and who genuinely has the skills they claim. That graph powers a recruiter product that makes LinkedIn Recruiter look like a keyword search. Then an API that every platform needing to trust a human being plugs into. Then a verification product that kills the fake CV industry. Then a passport that becomes the professional identity layer for Africa — and eventually for any market underserved by the Western credential system. Not a profile page. Not a job board. The trust infrastructure of professional Africa. That is the conspiracy.

Document version: 1.0 — ProofileSA Founding Session Operating name: ProofileSA until proofile.com + proofile.app domains acquired (~\$10,000 budget) Next document: Pitch Deck